

What is the best way of organizing of an initiative or organization's indicators?

Larger initiatives or organizations often find that they have a large set of potential, and actual indicators. These sets can end up including hundreds of indicators. Such indicators are used by different parts of the organization or initiative for various management and reporting purposes.

Larger organizations and initiatives often run into a number of problems with such indicator sets. First, they find that the same indicator ends up being used in different parts of the organization or initiative. But in some cases, when it is used, it is called by a different name. Second, as staff change, time is spent re-identifying indicators that have been considered in the past but previously rejected for various technical reasons. Third, there can be a lack of clarity as to whether indicators are controllable by the organization. Fourth, staff can propose many indicators that are not actually indicators in the sense that they can be affordably and feasibly measured.

The Organization or Initiative Indicator Inventory Tool (D7) provides a way of organizing and managing any organization's or initiative's indicators in a spreadsheet or database. It consists of the organization or initiative keeping, and keeping up to date, an inventory of all indicators that have ever been considered by the organization or initiative. This should include ones that are and ones that are not, currently being used as internal or external indicators.

This indicator inventory typically contains columns such as the following: a permanent unique identifying number for each indicator in the inventory; indicator name; alternative names for the indicator; whether the indicator has been rejected as not feasible or affordable, and if it has been rejected, the reason why it was rejected; if the indicator was used in the past; whether any other organization or initiative may have an interest in assisting with collecting the indicator; if the indicator is currently being used: where the indicator is being used (i.e. in which internal or external reporting documents); what database it is collected in; the cost of collecting it (high, medium, low); whether it is controllable by the organization or initiative; who is responsible for collecting it; and, whether a target and date for achievement has been set on the indicator.